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Performance Voting in a Multiparty Contest: A Case Study of the 2024 Taiwan's Presidential Election

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ABSTRACT

This study examines the influence of performance assessments on voting behavior in Taiwan's 2024 presidential election. Drawing on cross-sectional and panel survey data, we find evidence of performance voting. Additionally, candidate evaluation and presidential approval emerge as strong predictors of vote choice, underscoring the continuing relevance of electoral accountability. These findings suggest that identity-based voting does not eliminate instrumental evaluation, but coexists with it. This extends the scope of performance voting theory to highly structured and polarized electoral environments.

KEYWORDS

Performance voting;
candidate evaluation;
presidential election; Taiwan

Introduction

In democratic societies, elections provide citizens with an opportunity to express their discontent with government performance. Yet, voters often remain loyal to party lines when making electoral choices. The emergence of a viable third-party presidential candidate is therefore a rare and disruptive event in a two-party system. Such occurrences can unsettle established patterns of partisanship and voter behaviour. A classic example is the 1992 U.S. presidential election, where Ross Perot, an independent businessman with no prior political experience, captured nearly 19% of the popular vote. His success revealed not only widespread dissatisfaction with the two major parties but also voters' willingness to respond to performance- and issue-based appeals beyond traditional partisan loyalties.

Taiwan's 2024 presidential election presents a similarly compelling case. For the first time in its democratic history, a third-party candidate – Ko Wen-je of the Taiwan People's Party (TPP) secured over a quarter of the national vote in a three-way race against the Democratic Progressive Party (DPP) and the Kuomintang (KMT).

In established democracies, recent scholarship has emphasised the importance of performance voting. Unlike the partisanship-issue-candidate voting model (Achen, 1992), performance voting theory posits that voters prefer the party that can address the valence issues. When people widely share concerns over some issues, such as economy or foreign policy, they may vote for the candidate that can address the problems better

than others. This theory is inspired by Stokes (1963, pp. 373–374), which argues that voters care less about issue positions when parties converge on ideology. Instead, voters may emphasise positive or negative assessment of parties in terms of certain goals or conditions. The ‘valence issue’, such as economic prosperity and war, may coexist with positional conflicts.

In Taiwan, a country that emerged during the third wave of democratisation (Huntington, 1991), the primary political cleavage centers on national identity: while some citizens identify as Taiwanese, others consider themselves Chinese. This identity divide is deeply intertwined with partisanship and strongly associated with cross-strait policy, particularly in relation to China, which frequently asserts hostility through military exercises and diplomatic pressure. Against this backdrop, the DPP and KMT have been competing on the dimension of national identity since democratisation. However, the rise of the TPP signals a potential shift to governance and evaluation. We argue that the 2024 election demonstrates the growing salience of performance voting in Taiwan.

This research would contribute to the literature of electoral studies in three ways. First, most existing studies examine performance voting in binary electoral settings. By analyzing Taiwan’s 2024 presidential election – a rare three-candidate contest with three viable alternatives – we test whether voters can still identify and select the candidate best able to address the most important issue under conditions of increased choice complexity and potential correlation among alternatives. This allows us to assess the scope conditions of performance voting beyond two-party systems.

Second, Taiwan provides a theoretically demanding context due to its strong and enduring identity cleavage structured around cross-Straits relations. Our analysis therefore evaluates whether performance-based considerations retain explanatory power even in one of the most identity-structured electoral contexts. The finding is that identity-based voting does not eliminate instrumental evaluation, but coexists with it. This extends the scope of performance voting theory to highly structured and polarised electoral environments.

Methodologically, we also contribute by embedding performance voting within a random utility framework that allows us to model choice among multiple viable candidates using alternative-specific predictors. This approach provides a more precise test of how performance evaluations operate in a multiparty setting, where voters must choose among more than two competing options.

The remainder of this article proceeds as follows. Section ‘Literature Review’ reviews the literature on democratic values and democratic development. Section ‘the 2024 Taiwan’s Presidential Election’ describes the candidates and issues in this election. Section ‘Research Hypotheses’ presents four major hypotheses. ‘Data and Variables’ introduces cross-sectional and panel data, and variables. Section ‘Random Utility Model’ illustrates statistical models and presents analysis results. Section ‘Conclusion’ concludes the article.

Literature Review

Performance Voting Theory

Conventional social-psychological voting theory conceptualises partisanship as a long-standing attachment to political parties. It is the core of the voting decision process

(Campbell et al., 1960). Issue positions and candidate evaluations are constrained by partisanship, and jointly determine voting choice. Party identification is stable because it is a form of social group identities (Green et al., 2002).

However, in other studies, candidate evaluation is placed in the central position of the voting model instead of partisanship (Jackson, 1975; Markus & Converse, 1979b). The voting choice is a function of candidate evaluations and lagged voting decision. Party attachment influences voting behaviour through candidate evaluation. Comparative research on change of partisanship suggests that positional changes by parties or economic conditions can lead voters to update their partisanship (Kollman & Jackson, 2021). Those findings imply that party-oriented politics has been moving toward a performance-based pattern.

Based on the framework of Stoke (1963), the theory of performance voting suggests that media coverage or agenda setting may raise individuals' attention to certain issues. People who are concerned about the issue may be likely to see the difference between candidates on that issue. Therefore, people who feel an issue is important are motivated to support the incumbent based on their evaluations of the government's performance on that issue (Fournier et al., 2003).

Clarke, Kornberg, et al. (2009) observe electoral choice between Labor vs. another party and multiple choices in the 2005 British general election. They measure party performance by asking respondents which party is the best on the most important issue. The result is that influence of party's performance is nothing less than that of party leaders, party-issue proximity, and party identification. Using the party judged to be closest to individual voters on their self-identified most important issue as an indicator of valence issue voting, Clarke et al. (2009) report that most American and Canadian voters rely on valence issues that help them find the best candidate on crucial issues.

Hobolt et al. (2013) examine the influence of health care and economic evaluations on voting behaviour in 27 European countries. They highlight the importance of government and institution clarity, and they find positive correlation between intention to vote for the incumbent party and policy evaluations regardless of degree of clarity. Ecker et al. (2016) analyze performance voting on another salient issue: corruption. They find that corruption perception has a significant negative effect on incumbent voting. The negative effect may depend on whether government turnover would happen. Oktay (2018) focuses on foreign policy performance voting in Europe. His comparative analysis shows that when foreign policy disapproval is high, parties holding both the prime ministerial office and the foreign affairs ministry in either coalition or semi-presidential government receive fewer votes. Their findings imply that voters can assess government's handling of foreign policy, considering the clarity of responsibility.

Like other concepts in political behaviour, research on electoral accountability has been extended to multiparty systems and proportional representation contexts, where responsibility attribution may be more complex but remains analytically meaningful (Duch & Stevenson, 2008; Hobolt et al., 2013; Powell & Whitten, 1993). This literature is especially relevant for Latin America, where there are many multiparty presidential systems with different voting rules. The economic component of voting behaviour and electoral accountability have aroused academic discussion (Diaz-Cayeros et al., 2016; Murillo & Visconti, 2017; Singer, 2013; Singer & Carlin, 2013).

The existing literature suggests that performance voting can operate under a wide range of institutional arrangements. However, most studies have focused on Europe and the Americas, leaving East Asian democracies comparatively underexplored. One notable exception is Ho et al. (2013). Ho and his colleagues examine performance voting in Taiwan's presidential and mayoral elections, arguing that Taiwanese voters tend to prioritise valence issues and prefer leaders who are perceived as competent in addressing these concerns, rather than aligning strictly along ideological lines. Their findings suggest that voters are more likely to support the incumbent party based on its perceived performance on the most salient issues.

While Ho et al. (2013) provide strong evidence for performance voting in Taiwan, their analysis is limited to electoral settings with only two major choices. This raises questions about the applicability of their conclusions to multiparty systems or runoff elections, where more than two candidates are typically in contention. In such contexts, are voters still able to identify the candidate best equipped to address the most pressing issues? To test this hypothesis, it is essential to estimate a multinomial choice model instead of a binary one. However, the correlated alternative problem may occur if two or more choices are correlated.

Issue and Identity-based Voting

A separate body of research emphasises positional issue voting and identity-based attachments as key determinants of electoral choice. Spatial models of voting (Downs, 1957) assume that voters and parties can be located on an ideological dimension and that voters choose the party whose position is closest to their own. In Taiwan, the independence–unification issue provides precisely such a dominant dimension: since the 1990s, disagreements over whether Taiwan should move toward formal independence or eventual unification with China have structured party competition, media discourse, and mass political identities (Achen & Wang, 2017; Hsieh & Niou, 1996).

In this context, issue voting refers to the support for the political party whose position on the independence–unification spectrum most closely aligns with the voter's own views. Identity-based voting is distinct. There is a strong correlation between Taiwanese versus Chinese identity and support for the DPP versus the KMT. However, this identity also encompasses broader social and historical connections that can influence political attitudes, even when specific policy information is lacking. To measure issue voting, we assess the spatial proximity between respondents' self-placement on the independence–unification spectrum and their perceptions of each party's stance. In contrast, identity is captured through Taiwanese or Chinese self-identification and party affiliation.

By distinguishing performance voting from issue voting and identity-based attachments, this paper examines whether evaluations of performance on the most important problem independently shape vote choice in Taiwan's 2024 three-candidate contest after controlling for issue proximity, identity, and partisanship.

Recent work by Rich (2024) uses survey-based preference rankings to simulate how alternative voting systems would have allocated the 2024 presidency among Lai, Hou, and Ko. The analysis sheds light on voters' underlying ordering of the three candidates under counterfactual electoral rules. Our contribution is complementary: rather than

modelling hypothetical rankings, we focus on actual first-round vote choice under Taiwan's plurality system and examine how performance evaluations, issue proximity, and partisanship shape those observed choices.

The 2024 Taiwan's Presidential Election: Correlated Alternatives?

Taiwan's 2024 presidential election was a three-way race. The incumbent DPP nominated Vice President William Lai, a former mayor of Tainan City known for his effective governance and strong advocacy for Taiwanese independence. The KMT, the second-largest party, endorsed Hou You-yi, the current mayor of New Taipei City. Meanwhile, Ko Wen-je, the former mayor of Taipei City, represented the Taiwan People's Party TPP. The election concluded with Lai securing 40% of the vote, followed by Hou with 33.5%, and Ko with 26.5%. This marked an unprecedented third consecutive presidential victory for the DPP.

Table 1 shows presidential vote shares since Taiwan's first direct election in 1996. With the exception of 2000 and 2024, third-party or independent candidates have typically won only a small fraction of the vote, and the DPP and KMT together have captured the overwhelming majority of support. In 2024, however, Ko Wen-je of the TPP obtained 26.46 percent of the vote, making this the first presidential contest in more than two decades in which a third candidate won over one quarter of the vote. The 2024 election therefore constitutes a rare three-candidate contest with three genuinely viable alternatives in the past two decades. On this basis, we reposition 2024 not as a case in which partisan identities 'disappear', but as a critical test of whether performance-based considerations retain substantial explanatory power in a system long organised by a strong blue-green partisan and identity cleavage.

Historically, the KMT, which traces its roots to Sun Yat-sen and Chiang Kai-shek, enjoyed strong support from civil servants, the middle class, and farmers. The party has long emphasised Chinese cultural ties, promoting the idea of shared heritage between Taiwan and China. However, as China has escalated its coercive posture toward Taiwan in recent years, the KMT has faced growing criticism – especially from younger, more liberal voters – for appearing overly conciliatory toward Beijing. In contrast, the DPP has taken a firm stance against Chinese unification efforts and military threats, increasing defense spending to bolster Taiwan's security. Positioned between the two major parties, the TPP seeks to strike a centrist tone. Its leader, Ko Wen-je, has gained popularity through his candid communication style and his commitment to combating corruption and ending ideological polarization.

Table 1. Presidential election vote share, 1996–2024 (%).

Year	KMT	DPP	Third Party	Other
2024	33.49	40.05	26.46	–
2020	38.61	57.13	4.26	–
2016	31.04	56.12	12.83	–
2012	51.60	45.63	2.77	–
2008	58.45	41.55	–	–
2004	49.89	50.11	–	–
2000	23.10	39.30	36.84	0.76
1996	54.00	21.10	14.90	9.98

The TPP presents itself as a pragmatic and technocratic alternative to the traditional blue–green camps, emphasising governance competence over ideology. Consistent with this image, the TPP attracts disproportionate support from younger, urban, and politically disaffected voters skeptical of entrenched partisan conflict. On cross-Strait relations, the party adopts a deliberately moderate and ambiguous position, criticising both the DPP's perceived provocation of Beijing and the KMT's perceived accommodation of China while broadly supporting the status quo. Together with Ko Wen-je's personalised leadership style, these differences suggest that the TPP should be modelled as a distinct electoral alternative rather than collapsed into a broader 'blue camp'. This distinction is especially important for our analysis of performance voting, since Ko's campaign foregrounded managerial competence and technocratic problem-solving in ways that may appeal to voters with weaker partisan or identity attachments. The resulting three-way competition creates the conditions for the potential 'third body problem' and motivates our subsequent tests of the independence of irrelevant alternatives in the random-utility framework.

Viewing the DPP as their common opponent, the KMT and TPP entered into intensive negotiations to form a joint presidential ticket. The strategic rationale was clear: the two parties hoped to complement each other's electoral base – the TPP appealing to younger, urban voters, and the KMT maintaining strong support among older and rural constituencies. Both parties also criticised the DPP's handling of cross-strait relations, accusing it of provoking Beijing and contributing to rising tensions.

Despite these shared interests, the two parties were unable to reach an agreement on who would lead the joint ticket. The KMT regarded the TPP as a junior partner, while the TPP saw the KMT as a waning force, fragmented, and out of touch with shifting voter preferences. The talks ultimately collapsed just before the registration deadline and each party proceeded independently. As a result, voters remained largely aligned with their partisan affiliations. At the same time, Ko's personalistic appeal and the TPP's anti-establishment rhetoric attracted a non-trivial share of voters with weaker partisan attachments, making it essential to model the DPP, KMT, and TPP as three distinct options rather than collapsing the latter two into a single 'blue camp' alternative.

The attempt to form a joint ticket highlights certain ideological and strategic commonalities between the KMT and TPP. Nevertheless, the two parties ultimately remained distinct choices on the ballot. To accurately test our performance voting hypothesis, it is crucial to treat the KMT, TPP, and DPP as separate alternatives. From a modelling perspective, this three-way structure raises the classic 'third body problem': when two alternatives share overlapping constituencies, their utilities may be correlated, potentially violating the independence of irrelevant alternatives (IIA) assumption that underpins the multinomial logit model. If the IIA assumption holds, we will employ the multinomial logit model (MNL). If not, we will turn to the multinomial probit model (MNP), which relaxes the IIA constraint.

Research Hypotheses

As discussed above, performance voting is evaluated using the responses of voters to the question of which candidate is the most capable of addressing the nation's most important problem (Clarke, Kornberg, et al., 2009; Ho et al., 2013). In this study, we also define performance voting as voters supporting the candidate they believe can best handle the

pressing issue. Therefore, we assume that choice of a party's nominee as the best candidate to address the most important problem will increase the probability of voting for that candidate.

H1: Choice of a party's nominee as the best candidate to address the most important problem has positive impact on the probability of voting for the candidate

The second hypothesis states that people that agree with the party's position on the independence-unification issue tend to vote for the party. Since the 1990s, whether Taiwan should declare independent from China or prepare for re-unification with China has been a dominant issue (Hsieh & Niou, 1996). Unlike other valence or policy issues that vary by election cycle, the independence-unification divide remains a consistent and foundational axis of political conflict, structuring not only party competition but also identity, media narratives, and cross-strait policy debates. In this study, we ask the respondents about their positions on the independence-unification issue and each party's position, then computing the absolute value of the difference between the respondent and each party. In doing so, we measure the proximity of issue position between the respondent and three political parties (Tsai & Tan, 2022).

This approach is grounded in the spatial theory of voting developed by Downs (1957). According to Downs, voters and political parties can be located on a single ideological spectrum, and voters are assumed to choose the party whose position is closest to their own in order to maximise utility. The smaller the ideological distance between a voter and a party, the more likely the voter is to perceive that party as representing their interests. In the context of Taiwan's politics, where the independence-unification issue dominates the ideological landscape, this spatial model provides a compelling framework for understanding vote choice.

H2: Proximity of issue position is positively associated with the probability of voting for the candidate

Adams et al. (2005, p. 20) argue that voters often exhibit biases toward parties or candidates due to 'non-policy-related motivations'. Information about candidates' personal traits can significantly influence voter judgment (Lodge et al., 1989). Voters may assess a candidate's record, experience, competencies, and personal characteristics (Campbell et al., 1960). Key dimensions of candidate evaluation include competence, integrity, reliability, charisma, trustworthiness, and likability (Miller et al., 1986; Miller & Shanks, 1996). Conversely, candidates who project negative or threatening impressions may alienate potential supporters (Mattes et al., 2010). As Hacker (1995) notes, candidate images can serve as both a filter and an amplifier of political messaging, directly shaping how voters perceive and respond to electoral choices. Candidate evaluations are therefore central to voting behaviour, with partisanship serving as a guiding heuristic for those undecided between alternatives (Markus & Converse, 1979a).

From a utility-based perspective, voter support for a candidate is driven by the perceived benefits of that candidate's victory (Page & Jones, 1979). It is rational for voters to support the candidate they view most favourably and expect to benefit from. In two-party contests, the difference in 'feeling thermometer' scores between candidates reflects the net utility gain. In a three-candidate race, each candidate's score independently indicates their relative utility to the voter.

In Taiwan's presidential elections, candidates are often the focal point of public attention. They are expected to articulate platforms and offer solutions to pressing national issues. Typically, presidential candidates also serve as the leaders of their respective parties, though campaign teams may operate separately from the party headquarters. The media and social platforms closely scrutinise all aspects of a candidate's public and personal life, making negative campaigning – targeting personality, financial records, and policy stances – commonplace. As a result, voters are exposed to extensive information about each candidate. Wang and Chen (2017) contend that competence and personal character are the most important dimensions of candidate evaluation and that evaluations of candidate personal traits correlate with evaluation of the image of the party on important issues. Based on this context, we propose the following hypothesis regarding candidate evaluations. Instead of treating candidate evaluation as a novel theoretical contribution, we present it as a benchmark expectation derived from candidate-centered and valence-based models of voting. In this study, it serves as a standard against which the explanatory contribution of performance voting can be assessed.

H3: Candidate evaluation is positively associated with the probability of voting for the candidate

Since political parties are the most important political organisations in contemporary politics, attachment to political parties is an important political attitude. The voting decision process is conceptualised as a causal funnel in which partisanship is the most important long-term force (Campbell et al., 1960, 1966). Although candidate evaluations and issue positions are more closely related to the voting act than partisanship, party identification has a direct and indirect influence on the choice of votes (Niemi & Weisberg, 1993). Analyses of single elections, multiple elections, and panel data has found that party identification has a consistent impact on the voting decision (Bartels, 2000; Goldberg, 1966; Hartwig et al., 1980).

Taiwan is not an exception to party line voting. Due to the complex relationship with China, the divide between Taiwanese and Chinese identity, in parallel with the independence-unification issue, is embedded in partisan allegiance (Achen & Wang, 2017). People who support independence and identify themselves as Taiwanese tend to have a relationship with the DPP. In contrast, KMT identifiers tend to prefer unification and Chinese nationalism. As for the TPP partisans, their issue position is moderate than the KMT and DPP and their identity is mixed. Because partisanship aligns with the cleavage of Taiwanese identity, we expect that partisanship is influential in this three-candidate contest.

Beyond partisan allegiances, institutions and personalised campaign environments also direct voter attention to individual candidate characteristics. While candidate and party evaluations are often correlated, they represent analytically distinct dimensions of voter judgment (Carey & Shugart, 1995). As Carey and Shugart previously theorise, electoral systems vary in the incentives they provide to cultivate a personal vote support based on individual rather than party reputation. In political systems where individual officeholders are directly visible and accountable to voters, such as Taiwan's semi-presidential model with direct presidential elections, these institutional configurations encourage voters to evaluate leaders independently of their partisan affiliation (Carey & Shugart, 1995; Swindle, 2002). Taiwan's semi-presidential

structure, which blends presidential leadership with parliamentary coordination, amplifies this dynamic of presidentialization of politics (Shen, 2014). The effect is further reinforced by a highly personalised campaign environment in which party organisations must adapt to candidate-centered mobilisation strategies (Chung, 2024).

Also, from the perspective of valence politics (Clarke et al., 2011; Stokes, 1963), Taiwanese voters tend to focus on candidate traits such as competence, integrity, and problem-solving ability. These qualities are ones about which there is broad societal consensus, rather than on policy positions alone. The rise of valence-based voting aligns with the empirical design of this study: survey respondents were asked ‘which candidate could best solve the most important problem’, emphasising perceived efficacy rather than ideological proximity. This operationalisation captures public evaluations of candidates on competence-oriented dimensions that transcend partisan identities. This framework clarifies why voters disillusioned with traditional party politics can still respond positively to perceived technocratic or pragmatic candidates whose charisma and managerial style communicate credibility and independence (Clarke et al., 2011). As with candidate evaluation, partisanship is included here as a benchmark predictor rather than as a novel hypothesis. The expectation that stronger partisan identification increases the probability of supporting the corresponding party follows directly from the classic social psychological literature on vote choice. In this study, the purpose is to establish the baseline strength of enduring partisan attachments against which the explanatory role of performance voting can be compared

H4: Party identification with a party is positively associated with the probability of voting for its candidate

As discussed above, our candidate choice model includes four choice-specific variables: candidate evaluations, proximity to the issue position, perceived candidate performance, and partisanship. For each respondent, the likelihood of choosing a particular candidate increases with positive evaluations, expected performance, and party identification, and decreases with greater incongruence on issue positions. In addition to these choice-specific variables, we incorporate individual-specific variables such as Taiwanese/Chinese identity, presidential approval, and prior voting behaviour (only for panel data). Identity is a particularly salient factor in Taiwan; both identity and partisanship are long-standing predispositions that serve as foundational influences on voting decisions. Individuals who identify as Taiwanese are more likely to support the DPP over the KMT or TPP. Therefore, including identity in the model is essential for accurately estimating the effects of candidate evaluations and performance-based voting. Presidential approval also plays a key role: those who approve of President Tsai are more likely to support her successor, Vice President William Lai. We include gender, age (grouped into five categories), and education (three levels) as control variables to ensure that the relationships between the dependent and independent variables are not confounded by social background. Because performance evaluations may themselves be associated with partisan and identity predispositions, our estimates should be interpreted as conditional associations rather than as fully exogenous causal effects.

Data and Variables

To test our hypotheses, we use data from the Taiwan Election and Democratization Study (TEDS) (Chen, 2025). The 2024 TEDS survey was conducted by the Election Study Center at National Chengchi University between January 15 and May 31, 2024, under the direction of Professor Lu-huei Chen. The research team drew a sample of 14,503 addresses, from which 1,206 face-to-face interviews were completed. Additionally, the study re-interviewed 1,972 of the 3,547 respondents originally surveyed in TEDS 2021. The distribution of gender, age, and education is compared in Appendix Table A1, A2, and A3. There is no significant discrepancy between two datasets in terms of these three characteristics. The data are very important because face-to-face interview is one of the most trusted ways to gather authentic, high-quality responses to sensitive questions, such as identity and voting behaviour. Therefore, the data-generating process is valid for this study.

Our analysis draws on both independent cross-sectional data and panel data. A key advantage of using panel data is the ability to incorporate past vote choice (from 2020) as a predictor of vote choice in 2024. This allows us to investigate whether supporters of the DPP in 2020 shifted their support to the TPP in the most recent election. For more information, visit TEDS official site. (<http://teds.nccu.edu.tw/main.php>)

In these two studies, our dependent variable is the choice of votes between Lai, Hou, and Ko. Among the 1,206 respondents from the cross-sectional samples, 772 people answered whom they voted for. Figure 1 presents the distribution of vote choices. In our sample, 41.8% of respondents voted for the DPP, 33% for the KMT, and 25.2%

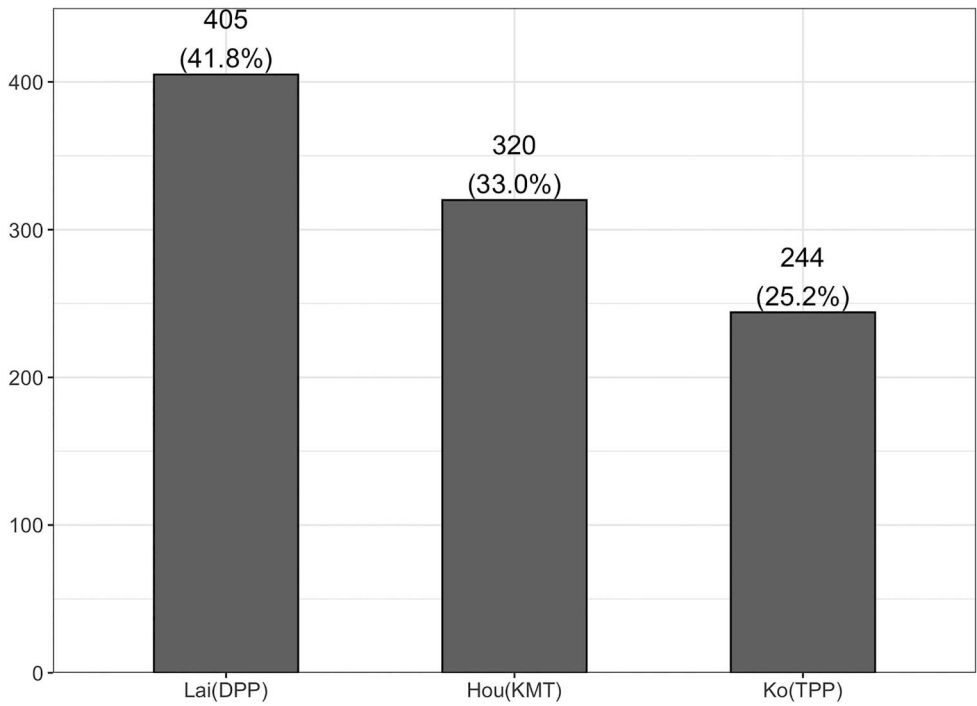


Figure 1. Vote Choices of Respondents in Independent Samples. Source: Chen (2025).

for the TPP. By comparison, the actual election results were 40% for Lai, 33.5% for Hou, and 26.5% for Ko.

Figure 2 shows the frequencies of vote choice in the panel data. There are 969 respondents responding to this question. There are 49.6 percent of respondents voting for the DPP, 27.2 percent the KMT, and 23.2 percent the TPP. Respondents who participated in both the 2020 and 2024 surveys may be more politically engaged and more likely to maintain consistent partisan attachments over time, especially those who previously supported the incumbent DPP. In contrast, the cross-sectional sample includes newly recruited respondents, including younger or less politically active individuals, who may be more open to switching support or backing a third-party candidate like the TPP. Consequently, the panel sample may overrepresent stable DPP supporters relative to the broader electorate.

Since Performance voting is operationalised by identifying which candidate voters see fit to address the most pressing national issue, the measurement of *performance* is based on a two-step question sequence. First, respondents are asked to identify what they perceive as the most important problem facing the country. Immediately following this, they are asked which candidate they think is most capable of addressing that problem. For each respondent, we generate a binary variable indicating their choice of candidate: a value of 1 is assigned if the respondent selects Lai, Hou, or Ko as the best candidate for the issue, and 0 otherwise. This procedure results in three separate binary indicators, each corresponding to one of the three major candidates.

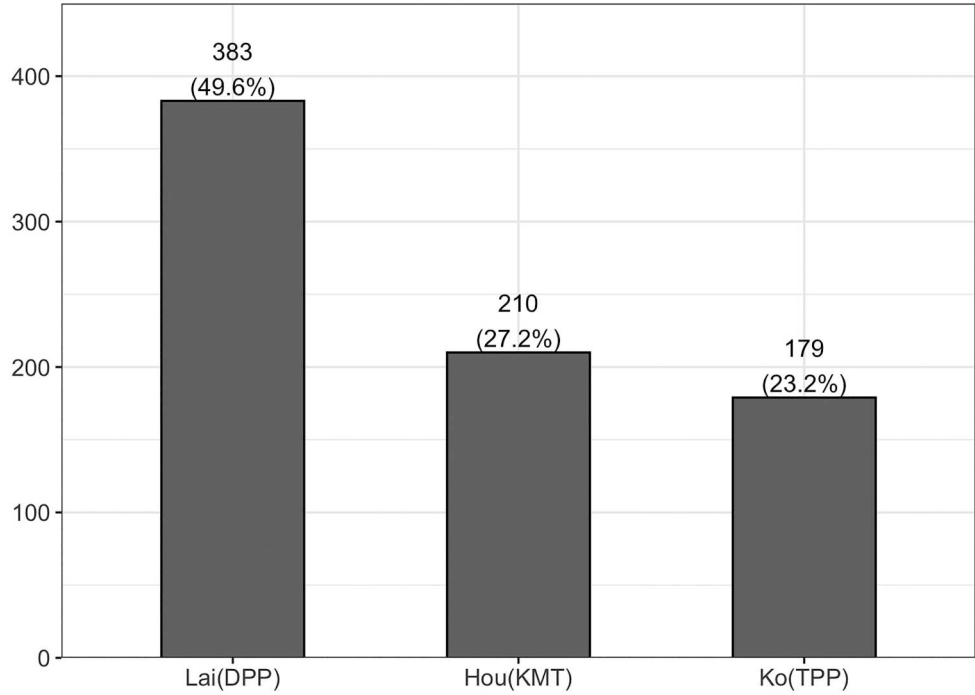


Figure 2. Vote Choices of Respondents in Panel Data. Source: Chen (2025).

Proximity to party positions on the independence–unification issue is measured by calculating the absolute difference between each respondent's own position and their perception of each party's stance on the issue. We construct three separate variables to represent the proximity between the respondent and each of the three major parties, respectively.

Candidate evaluation is measured by asking respondents how much they like each of the three candidates on a 1–10 scale. The thermometer score represents a general assessment that reflects individuals' overall impressions toward each candidate.

Partisanship is drawn from three questions. First of all, respondents are asked: 'Do you usually think of yourself as close to any particular party?' If they say yes, the follow-up question is which party they feel closest to. If respondents say no, the follow-up question is: 'Do you feel yourself a little closer to one of the political parties than the others?' After finding out which party respondents identify with, we ask respondents, 'Do you feel very close to this party, somewhat close, or not very close?' Based on the sequence of answers, we construct a 0–3 scale, where 3 means very close, 2 somewhat close, 1 not very close, and 0 otherwise.

In addition to these three alternative-specific variables, partisanship, Taiwanese identity, current president's approval, voting choice in 2020, and demographic variables are included in the voting choice models. Those variables are individual-specific variables; they vary across individuals but they are invariant across choices. All of the question wordings and operationalisation is in Table B of Appendix.

Random Utility Model

Test of IIA Assumption

Let the utility that individual i derives from choosing alternative $j \in \{1, 2, 3\}$ be defined as:

$$U_{ij} = \mathbf{X}_{ij}\beta + \mathbf{Z}_i\gamma_j + \varepsilon_{ij} \quad (1)$$

We assume that individual i chooses alternative j if and only if:

$$U_{ij} > U_{ik} \quad \forall k \neq j \quad (2)$$

In Equation 1, $\mathbf{X}_{ij}$ is a vector of choice-specific variables (e.g. candidate evaluation, issue proximity, expected performance, partisanship). β is the vector of coefficients shared across choices. They represent the effects of attributes of choices on individual's preference.

$\mathbf{Z}_i$ is a vector of individual-specific covariates (e.g. identity, presidential approval, voting choice in 2020, and demographics), and γ_j is a vector of alternative-specific coefficients for $\mathbf{Z}_i$, quantifying the influence of individual characteristics on candidate choice.

Finally, ε_{ij} is the error term capturing unobserved preferences. In the multinomial logit model, the error terms ε_{ij} are assumed to be i.i.d. Type I extreme value. In the multinomial probit model, they follow a multivariate normal distribution.

The Independence of Irrelevant Alternatives (IIA) assumption is central to the multinomial logit (MNL) model. It implies that the relative odds of choosing between any two alternatives are unaffected by the presence or characteristics of other alternatives.

Table 2. Hausman-McFadden IIA Test Results.

Test	Omitted Alternative	Test Statistic	<i>p</i> -value
cross-sectional data	DPP	27.605	0.2771
Panel data	DPP	5.89	0.31

Source: Chen (2025).

Note: Both tests fail to reject the null hypothesis of IIA ($p \geq 0.05$), indicating no significant violation of the IIA assumption.

Mathematically, for alternatives j and k , the ratio of choice probabilities satisfies:

$$\frac{P_{ij}}{P_{ik}} = \frac{\exp(V_{ij})}{\exp(V_{ik})}$$

where: V_{ij} and V_{ik} are the deterministic components of utility.

To test whether the IIA assumption holds, we employ the Hausman-McFadden (HM) test. The test compares the parameter estimates from the full model (with all alternatives) to a restricted model (with one or more alternatives removed). The test statistic is:

$$H = (\hat{\beta}_R - \hat{\beta}_F)^T [\hat{Var}(\hat{\beta}_R) - \hat{Var}(\hat{\beta}_F)]^{-1} (\hat{\beta}_R - \hat{\beta}_F)$$

where: $\hat{\beta}_F$ and $\hat{\beta}_R$ are the vectors of coefficient estimates from the full and restricted models, respectively. $\hat{Var}(\cdot)$ is the estimated variance-covariance matrix.

Under the null hypothesis that IIA holds, H is asymptotically distributed as a chi-squared distribution with degrees of freedom equal to the number of parameters being compared.

We conduct IIA test on both independent cross-sectional data and panel data. As shown in Table 1, the Hausman-McFadden test for IIA yielded a p -value greater than 0.05, indicating no statistically significant violation of the IIA assumption. Therefore, the multinomial logit model is appropriate for this study, as the alternatives appear to be independent and the model specification does not violate the IIA property (Table 2).¹

Multinomial Logit Models

Since the IIA assumption holds, we estimate MNL because its estimates are easier to interpret.² First of all, we test our hypotheses with cross-sectional data. In Table 3, each coefficient represents the change in the log-odds of choosing that category (e.g. KMT, TPP) over the baseline (e.g. DPP) for a one-unit increase in the predictor.

A one-unit increase in the best candidate on the most important issue is associated with an increase of 0.551 in the log-odds of choosing KMT or TPP over DPP. The corresponding odds ratio is 1.734, so the odds of choosing KMT or TPP over DPP are about 73.4% higher for each one-unit increase in this variable. As for ideological distance between individuals and their perceived positions of parties, the odds of choosing KMT or TPP over DPP are roughly 20.7% decrease in the odds of choosing KMT or TPP over DPP. The coefficient of candidate evaluation is 0.761, so a one-unit increase in this variable raises the odds of choosing KMT over DPP by a factor of 2.140, effectively doubling the odds. Similarly, partisan strength significantly influences candidate choice. A one-unit increase in KMT or TPP partisanship more than doubles the odds of selecting that party over the DPP ($e^{0.765} = 2.148$).

Table 3. Multinomial logit estimates of performance voting (cross-sectional).

Variable	Choice-specific	KMT vs DPP	TPP vs DPP
Intercept		2.376 (1.938)	1.426 (1.954)
Expected Performance	0.551** (0.194)		
Position Incongruence	−0.232** (0.078)		
Candidate Evaluation	0.761*** (0.100)		
Partisan Strength	0.765*** (0.126)		
Female		−0.376 (0.502)	0.346 (0.480)
age530_39		1.357 (0.904)	0.580 (0.697)
age540_49		1.249 (0.850)	0.694 (0.695)
age550_59		1.618 (0.950)	−0.710 (0.929)
age560_		1.675 (1.023)	0.699 (0.969)
edu3High School		−0.222 (0.862)	−0.258 (0.950)
edu3University		0.901 (0.947)	1.122 (1.003)
Taiwanese Identity		0.069 (0.569)	−0.278 (0.548)
Tsai Approval		−1.051* (0.511)	−0.700 (0.514)
Log-Likelihood	−149.03		
McFadden R ²	0.799		
Likelihood ratio test	1190***		

Note: *** $p \leq 0.001$, ** $p \leq 0.01$, * $p \leq 0.05$. The reference category of age is 20–29 years old, and the reference category of education is elementary school.

Source: Chen (2025).

Among individual-level predictors, Tsai's approval stands out. A one-unit increase in Tsai's approval score reduces the odds of choosing KMT over DPP by approximately 65% ($1 - e^{-1.051} \approx 65\%$).

Table 4 shows the MNL coefficients for panel data. At the first glance, expected performance, candidate evaluation, and partisan strength are positively associated with choosing the KMT or TPP over the DPP. The log-odds of choosing KMT over DPP decrease when each one-unit increase in position incongruence. Tsai's approval score is negatively correlated with the odds of voting for the KMT over DPP. More importantly, a one-unit increase in the best candidate on the most important issue is associated with an increase of 0.675 in the log-odds of choosing KMT or TPP over DPP. The corresponding odds ratio is 1.964, which is only second to Tsai's approval. Compared to MNL of cross-sectional data in Table 3, valence issues seem to be more influential within people that have voted four years ago. They may have better knowledge of each candidate than new comers, thus they emphasise on the performance of candidates when making political choices (Ho et al., 2013, p. 481).

Table 5 presents the coefficients from the second MNL model estimated with panel data. In this model, we include two dummy variables to represent prior voting behaviour

Table 4. Multinomial logit estimates of performance voting (panel data).

Variable	Choice-specific	KMT vs DPP	TPP vs DPP
Intercept		3.321 (2.291)	2.402 (1.785)
Expected Performance	0.675*** (0.173)		
Position Incongruence	−0.174* (0.071)		
Candidate Evaluation	0.668*** (0.094)		
Partisan Strength	0.584*** (0.112)		
Female		−0.595 (0.491)	−0.276 (0.391)
Age 30–39		0.512 (1.815)	−1.012 (0.757)
Age 40–49		1.328 (1.766)	−1.775* (0.739)
Age 50–59		1.616 (1.817)	−2.096* (0.941)
Age 60+		1.633 (1.838)	−1.376 (0.930)
High School		−0.427 (0.915)	0.148 (1.145)
University		−0.396 (0.992)	0.347 (1.184)
Taiwanese Identity		−0.717 (0.503)	−0.157 (0.439)
Tsai Approval		−1.373** (0.432)	−0.369 (0.381)
Log-Likelihood	−164.2		
McFadden R ²	0.795		
Likelihood ratio test	1278***		

Note: *** $p \leq 0.001$, ** $p \leq 0.01$, * $p \leq 0.05$. The reference category of age is 20–29 years old, and the reference category of education is elementary school.

Source: Chen (2025).

(DPP vs. others, and KMT vs. others). The results show that a one-unit increase in the evaluation of the best candidate on the most important issue is associated with a 0.671 increase in the log-odds of choosing either the KMT or the TPP over the DPP. This corresponds to an odds ratio of 1.956, the largest among the choice-specific predictors. Prior support for the DPP in 2020 substantially reduces the odds of choosing the TPP over the DPP by 89.4% (calculated as $1 - e^{-2.253} = 89.4\%$), while prior support for the KMT has no statistically significant effect. Overall, prior voting behaviour slightly alters the odds ratios compared to the cross-sectional analysis.

Our analysis of both cross-sectional and panel data supports all four hypotheses. Moreover, we find that Tsai's approval rating reduces the likelihood of voters choosing Hou over Lai. This is consistent with the expectation that voters satisfied with the current president are unlikely to support the opposition parties. We also find that individuals who voted for the DPP four years ago are less likely to support the TPP in 2024. This result may seem counterintuitive, given the common belief that some TPP supporters were former DPP voters. As Figure 2 illustrates, however, DPP voters are overrepresented in our panel data. These voters likely maintained consistent support for the DPP across elections, which may have vastly inflated the negative association between voting for the DPP in 2020 and choosing the TPP in 2024.

Table 5. Multinomial logit estimates of performance voting with prior voting (panel data).

Variable	Choice-specific	KMT vs DPP	TPP vs DPP
Intercept		3.321 (2.291)	2.402 (1.785)
Expected Performance	0.675*** (0.173)		
Position Incongruence	−0.174* (0.071)		
Candidate Evaluation	0.668*** (0.094)		
Partisan Strength	0.584*** (0.112)		
Female		−0.595 (0.491)	−0.276 (0.391)
Age 30–39		0.512 (1.815)	−1.012 (0.757)
Age 40–49		1.328 (1.766)	−1.775* (0.739)
Age 50–59		1.616 (1.817)	−2.096* (0.941)
Age 60+		1.633 (1.838)	−1.376 (0.930)
High School		−0.427 (0.915)	0.148 (1.145)
University		−0.396 (0.992)	0.347 (1.184)
Taiwanese Identity		−0.717 (0.503)	−0.157 (0.439)
Tsai Approval		−1.373** (0.432)	−0.369 (0.381)
Log-Likelihood	−155.1		
McFadden R ²	0.806		
Likelihood ratio test	1296f***		

Note: *** $p \leq 0.001$, ** $p \leq 0.01$, * $p \leq 0.05$. The reference category of age is 20–29 years old, and the reference category of education is elementary school.

Source: Chen (2025).

Conclusion

Taiwan's 2024 presidential election was a rare three-candidate race. This unique setting provides an opportunity to test performance voting theory under multiparty competition. Our cross-sectional data analysis with a random utility model highlights performance voting, while also offering evidence in support of candidate evaluation and partisanship. Voters who perceive greater issue proximity to a party, who express stronger partisan attachments, and who evaluate the candidate more favourably are more likely to support that party. Additionally, approval of the incumbent president is negatively associated with voting for the major opposition party, the KMT. Furthermore, in the panel data analyses (with or without prior voting controls), candidate choice is associated with expected performance on the most important issue. Thus, the valence politics model consistently 'best its competitor', as Ho et al. (2013, p. 481) suggests.

Our findings show that voters consider both long-term party ideology and short-term candidate personality and likely performance into account as previous literature accounts (Campbell et al., 1960; Jackson, 1975; Page & Jones, 1979). Swing voters, weak partisans, and cross-pressured voters are particularly responsive to performance-based evaluations. We also confirm that performance voting theory can travel to multi-candidate elections

by employing a random utility framework to model choice among multiple viable candidates using alternative-specific predictors.

Beyond theoretical contributions, these findings carry important implications for Taiwan's political future. The evidence suggests that people from different positions on the ideological spectrum may vote for the candidate who can address the most important issue. In other words, traditional two-party alignment may not continue as voters become more responsive to performance-driven appeals. The rise of the TPP in 2024, fuelled by positive perceptions of Ko Wen-je's personal traits and perceived competence, may foster sentiment toward pragmatism over party identity. However, this pattern does not signal a collapse of Taiwan's two-party system. Instead, it reflects a cyclical change in which political parties must respond to a more demanding electorate that rewards personal credibility, policy competence, and cross-partisan appeal.

Future research should systematically investigate how perceptions of electoral viability influence candidate evaluations. A candidate with low poll numbers may be judged differently than one with higher support – even if their personal traits are identical – because voters often infer competence from electability or anticipated success. This dynamic is particularly critical in multiparty contests, where strategic calculations and perceptions of competence are often deeply intertwined. Future surveys would benefit from asking respondents not only which candidate is best equipped to solve the most important problem, but also how heavily they weigh performance versus electability when making vote choices. We further suggest that future surveys incorporate direct measures of the weight voters assign to performance considerations relative to partisanship, ideology, and candidate affect. Such data would provide a more precise assessment of when and for whom performance voting is most influential.

In terms of research design, panel data collected over multiple elections can identify the temporal dynamics between performance perceptions, candidate viability, and vote choice. An ideal design would follow the same respondents across multiple stages of the campaign and repeatedly measure performance evaluations, candidate viability perceptions, issue salience, and vote intentions. Such data would allow researchers to determine whether changes in perceived performance precede changes in vote preferences or merely reflect them.

Two limitations warrant consideration. First, the cross-sectional nature of much of the data limits our ability to make strong causal claims. Performance perceptions may themselves be shaped by prior partisanship, identity, or vote intentions, raising concerns about endogeneity that cannot be fully resolved within the current research design.

Second, the findings are based on a single election in Taiwan, a context characterised by a distinctive identity cleavage and cross-strait dynamics. While this setting provides a demanding test for performance voting, future research should examine whether similar patterns hold across different electoral systems and political environments to assess the broader generalizability of our conclusions.

Notes

1. Katz and King (1999) highlight the statistical interdependence inherent in multiparty electoral competition, where gains by one party necessarily imply losses for others. This insight underscores the importance of modeling vote choice as a simultaneous choice among multiple alternatives rather than as separate binary decisions.

2. To confirm that our results are similar in different model setups, we run binary logit regression models and report the estimates in Appendix (Table C1–C3). The results underscore the importance of expected performance of candidates. Tables D1–D3 report multinomial logit models incorporating an interaction between expected performance and issue proximity in order to assess whether the effect of performance voting depends on ideological congruence between voters and parties. Across all three models, the interaction term between expected performance and position incongruence fails to reach statistical significance. Voters who perceive a candidate as more capable of addressing the most important national problem are more likely to support that candidate regardless of their level of ideological congruence with the party.

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No potential conflict of interest was reported by the author(s).

Data Availability Statement

The data that support the findings of this study are openly available in Survey Research Data Archive, Academia Sinica at <https://doi.org/10.6141/TW-SRDA-D00260-1>.

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Appendix

Table A1. Comparison of gender distribution: panel vs. cross-sectional data.

Gender	Panel (n = 1972)	cross-sectional (n = 1206)
Male	992 (50.3%)	641 (53.1%)
Female	980 (49.7%)	565 (46.9%)

Note: Chi-squared test: $\chi^2(1) = 2.05$, $p = 0.152$.

Table A2. Comparison of age distribution: panel vs. cross-sectional data.

Age Group	Panel (n = 1965)	cross-sectional (n = 1201)
20–29	176 (9.0%)	127 (10.6%)
30–39	266 (13.5%)	157 (13.1%)
40–49	407 (20.7%)	235 (19.6%)
50–59	340 (17.3%)	215 (17.9%)
60+	776 (39.5%)	467 (38.9%)

Note: Chi-squared test: $\chi^2(4) = 0.48$, $p = 0.975$.

Table A3. Comparison of education levels: panel vs. cross-sectional data.

Education Level	Panel (n = 1970)	cross-sectional (n = 1205)
Junior High	429 (21.8%)	234 (19.4%)
High School	765 (38.8%)	452 (37.5%)
University	776 (39.4%)	519 (43.1%)

Note: Chi-squared test: $\chi^2(2) = 3.08$, $p = 0.214$.

Source: Chen (2025).

Table B. Question wordings of variables.

Variable	Item	Question	Options
Voting choice in 2024	I1 (P11)	In this presidential election on January 13th many people went to vote, while others, for various reasons, did not go to vote. Did you vote?	1=yes, 2=no
	I2 (PI2)	Which ticket did you vote for?	1=Ko, Wen-Je and Wu, Hsin-Ying, 2=Lai, Ching-Te and Hsiao, Bi-Khim, 3=Hou, Yu-lh and Jaw, Shau-Kong
Candidate evaluation	J2a(PJ2a)	What would you rate Lai, Ching-Te?	0=Strongly dislike, 10=Strongly like
	J2b(PJ2b)	What would you rate Hou, Yu-lh?	0=Strongly dislike, 10=Strongly like
	J2c(PJ2c)	What would you rate Ko, Wen-Je?	0=Strongly dislike, 10=Strongly like
Expected performance	J1a(PJ1a)	During the presidential election campaign, many different problems faced by our country were raised What do you think is the most important political problem facing Taiwan today?	1=Economic development, 2=Cross-strait problem, 3=National identity, ...
	J1b(PJ1b)	Which presidential candidate do you think is most capable of dealing with it?	1=Ko, Wen-Je and Wu, Hsin-Ying, 2=Lai, Ching-Te and Hsiao, Bi-Khim, 3=Hou, Yu-lh and Jaw, Shau-Kong
Independence-unification issue position	M5a(PM5a)	Sometimes people will talk about the question of Taiwan independence or the unification with China. Some people say that Taiwan should declare independence immediately. Others say that Taiwan and China should unify immediately. Still others have opinions between these two positions. This card lists eleven positions from independence (0) to unification (10). Which position do you occupy?	0=Taiwan should declare independence immediately, 10=Taiwan and China should unify immediately
	M5b(PM5b)	What position do you think KMT occupies?	0=Taiwan should declare independence immediately, 10=Taiwan and China should unify immediately
	M5c(PM5c)	What position do you think DPP occupies?	0=Taiwan should declare independence immediately, 10=Taiwan and China should unify immediately
	M5d(PM5d)	d What position do you think TPP occupies?	0=Taiwan should declare independence immediately, 10=Taiwan and China should unify immediately
Partisanship	H1 (P1a)	Do you usually think of yourself as close to any particular party?	1=yes, 2=no
	H1a (P1b)	Do you feel yourself a little closer to one of the political parties than the others?	1=yes, 2=no
	H1b (P1c)	Which party do you feel closest to?	1=KMT, 2=DPP, 41=TPP
	H1c (P1d)	Do you feel very close to this party, somewhat close, or not very close?	1=Very close, 2=Somewhat close, 3=Not very close

(Continued)

Table B. Continued.

Variable	Item	Question	Options
Tsai approval	C1(PC1)	Now thinking about the performance of the president Tsai, Ing-wen in general, how good or bad a job do you think the president did over the past 8 years? Has she done a very good job? A good job? A bad job? A very bad job?	1=very good job, 2=good job, 3=bad job, 4=very bad job
Prior voting	(PI7a)	In the January 2020 Presidential Election, who did you vote?	1=James C. Y. Soong and Yu, Hsiang (TPP), 2=Daniel K. Y. Han and Simon S. C. Chang (KMT), 3=Tsai, Ing-Wen and Lai, Ching-Te (DPP)
Taiwanese identity	N1a (G2)	In Taiwan, some people think they are Taiwanese There are also some people who think that they are Chinese. Do you consider yourself as Taiwanese, Chinese or both?	1=Taiwanese, 2=Both, 3=Chinese

Table C1. Binary logit regression models (cross-sectional data).

	DPP vs. others	KMT vs. others
(Intercept)	0.114 (0.062)	0.314 (0.068)
Expected Performance		
Lai	0.354*** (0.033)	−0.065 (0.036)
Hou	−0.018 (0.031)	0.329*** (0.034)
Position Incongruence		
KMT	−0.004 (0.005)	−0.015** (0.005)
DPP	−0.008 (0.004)	0.002 (0.005)
TPP	0.012** (0.004)	0.006 (0.005)
Candidate Evaluation		
Lai	0.003 (0.002)	0.007** (0.002)
Hou	−0.000 (0.002)	−0.003 (0.002)
Ko	−0.006* (0.003)	−0.008** (0.003)
Partisanship		
KMT	−0.146*** (0.035)	0.316*** (0.038)
DPP	0.325*** (0.033)	−0.122*** (0.036)
TPP	−0.118*** (0.034)	−0.156*** (0.036)
Female	−0.015 (0.017)	−0.025 (0.019)
30–39 years old	−0.040 (0.033)	0.043 (0.036)
40–49 years old	−0.014 (0.032)	0.033 (0.034)
50–59 years old	0.018 (0.034)	0.103 (0.037)
60+ years old	0.005 (0.034)	0.068 (0.037)
High School	0.009 (0.029)	−0.020 (0.032)

(Continued)

Table C1. Continued.

	DPP vs. others	KMT vs. others
University	−0.035 (0.031)	−0.027 (0.034)
Taiwanese Identity	0.007 (0.022)	0.019 (0.024)
Tsai's Approval	0.051*** (0.014)	−0.022 (0.015)
Num.Obs.	688	688
R2	0.805	0.749
AIC	−110.7	1.1
BIC	−11.0	100.9
Log.Lik.	77.360	21.443
RMSE	0.22	0.23

Note: *** $p \leq 0.001$; ** $p \leq 0.01$; * $p \leq 0.05$. Parentheses are standard errors. The reference category of age is 20–29 years old, and the reference category of education is elementary school.

Source: Chen (2025).

Table C2. Binary logit regression models without prior voting(panel data).

	DPP vs. others	KMT vs. others
(Intercept)	−0.106 (0.055)	0.312 (0.051)
Expected Performance		
Lai	0.447*** (0.027)	0.005 (0.025)
Hou	−0.003 (0.029)	0.452*** (0.026)
Position Incongruence		
KMT	0.005 (0.004)	−0.003 (0.004)
DPP	0.002 (0.004)	0.001 (0.004)
TPP	0.004 (0.004)	−0.001 (0.004)
Candidate Evaluation		
Lai	0.001 (0.004)	0.027*** (0.003)
Hou	0.032*** (0.004)	−0.019*** (0.004)
Ko	−0.021 (0.003)	−0.021*** (0.003)
Partisanship		
KMT	−0.063** (0.024)	0.133*** (0.022)
DPP	0.111*** (0.019)	−0.066*** (0.017)
TPP	−0.059 (0.033)	0.020 (0.030)
Female	0.015 (0.015)	−0.030 (0.013)
30–39 years old	0.085** (0.031)	−0.040 (0.028)
40–49 years old	0.090** (0.030)	0.039 (0.027)
50–59 years old	0.076* (0.033)	0.095** (0.030)
60+ years old	0.082* (0.032)	0.061* (0.030)
High School	0.007 (0.024)	0.010 (0.022)

(Continued)

Table C2. Continued.

	DPP vs. others	KMT vs. others
University	0.002 (0.026)	−0.007 (0.024)
Taiwanese Identity	0.044* (0.020)	−0.049** (0.018)
Tsai's Approval	0.034* (0.013)	−0.025* (0.012)
Num. Obs.	1197	1197
R ²	0.753	0.751
AIC	95.7	−106.1
BIC	207.6	5.8
Log Likelihood	−25.833	75.050
RMSE	0.25	0.23

Note: *** $p \leq 0.001$; ** $p \leq 0.01$; * $p \leq 0.05$. Parentheses are standard errors. The reference category of age is 20–29 years old, and the reference category of education is elementary school.
Source: Chen (2025).

Table C3. Binary logit regression models with prior voting (panel data).

	DPP vs. others	KMT vs. others
(Intercept)	−0.142 (0.075)	0.224 (0.066)
Expected Performance		
Lai	0.458*** (0.030)	0.012 (0.027)
Hou	0.056 (0.033)	0.377*** (0.029)
Position Incongruence		
KMT	0.001 (0.004)	0.000 (0.004)
DPP	0.000 (0.004)	0.003 (0.004)
TPP	0.006 (0.005)	−0.004 (0.004)
Candidate Evaluation		
Lai	0.002 (0.004)	0.023*** (0.003)
Hou	0.030*** (0.005)	−0.017*** (0.004)
Ko	−0.018*** (0.004)	−0.019*** (0.003)
Partisanship		
KMT	−0.064* (0.029)	0.098*** (0.025)
DPP	0.096*** (0.021)	−0.047** (0.019)
TPP	−0.068 (0.036)	0.012 (0.031)
Demographics		
Female	0.015 (0.016)	−0.019 (0.014)
30–39 years old	0.073 (0.041)	−0.024 (0.037)
40–49 years old	0.082 (0.040)	0.052 (0.035)
50–59 years old	0.072 (0.043)	0.082 (0.038)
60+ years old	0.072 (0.042)	0.058 (0.037)
High School	0.012 (0.025)	−0.002 (0.022)

(Continued)

Table C3. Continued.

	DPP vs. others	KMT vs. others
University	−0.007 (0.027)	−0.006 (0.024)
Prior Voting		
2021 KMT voter	0.003 (0.043)	0.197*** (0.038)
2021 DPP voter	0.109** (0.042)	−0.006 (0.037)
Identity and Evaluation		
Taiwanese Identity	0.031 (0.022)	−0.042* (0.019)
Tsai's Approval	0.026 (0.015)	−0.014 (0.013)
Num. Obs.	988	988
R ²	0.764	0.777
AIC	54.4	−193.8
BIC	171.9	−76.3
Log Likelihood	−3.204	120.876
RMSE	0.24	0.21

Note: *** $p \leq 0.001$; ** $p \leq 0.01$; * $p \leq 0.05$. Parentheses are standard errors. The reference category of age is 20–29 years old, and the reference category of education is elementary school.

Source: Chen (2025).

Table D1. Multinomial logit estimates of performance voting with interaction (cross-sectional).

Variable	Choice-specific	KMT vs DPP	TPP vs DPP
Intercept		2.387 (1.943)	1.460 (1.967)
Expected Performance	0.520* (0.263)		
Position Incongruence	−0.242* (0.096)		
Candidate Evaluation	0.760*** (0.100)		
Partisan Strength	0.762*** (0.127)		
Performance × Position	0.020 (0.114)		
Female		−0.381 (0.504)	0.344 (0.480)
Age 30–39		1.372 (0.909)	0.585 (0.697)
Age 40–49		1.248 (0.850)	0.690 (0.696)
Age 50–59		1.621 (0.951)	−0.710 (0.930)
Age 60+		1.684 (1.024)	0.700 (0.969)
High School		−0.229 (0.864)	−0.286 (0.963)
University		0.892 (0.949)	1.098 (1.013)
Taiwanese Identity		0.067 (0.570)	−0.280 (0.548)
Tsai's Approval		−1.051* (0.513)	−0.704 (0.516)
Log-Likelihood	−149.01		
McFadden R ²	0.799		
Likelihood ratio test	1190***		

Note: Standard errors are in parentheses. *** $p \leq .001$; ** $p \leq .01$; * $p \leq .05$.

Table D2. Multinomial logit estimates of performance voting with interaction (panel data).

Variable	Choice-specific	KMT vs DPP	TPP vs DPP
Intercept		3.476 (2.302)	2.431 (1.788)
Expected Performance	0.543* (0.268)		
Position Incongruence	−0.210* (0.093)		
Candidate Evaluation	0.673*** (0.095)		
Partisan Strength	0.584*** (0.112)		
Performance × Position	0.085 (0.133)		
Female		−0.584 (0.492)	−0.270 (0.391)
Age 30–39		0.423 (1.804)	−1.001 (0.757)
Age 40–49		1.259 (1.753)	−1.786* (0.740)
Age 50–59		1.494 (1.812)	−2.150* (0.945)
Age 60+		1.519 (1.832)	−1.402 (0.930)
High School		−0.490 (0.923)	0.112 (1.139)
University		−0.489 (1.007)	0.285 (1.180)
Taiwanese Identity		−0.701 (0.504)	−0.137 (0.439)
Tsai's Approval		−1.363** (0.434)	−0.355 (0.383)
Log-Likelihood	−163.99		
McFadden R ²	0.796		
Likelihood ratio test	1279***		

Note: Standard errors are in parentheses. *** $p \leq .001$; ** $p \leq .01$; * $p \leq .05$.

Table D3. Multinomial logit estimates of performance voting with interaction and prior voting (panel data).

Variable	Choice-specific	KMT vs DPP	TPP vs DPP
Intercept		4.174 (2.492)	4.273* (2.105)
Expected Performance	0.470 (0.276)		
Position Incongruence	−0.209* (0.097)		
Candidate Evaluation	0.664*** (0.099)		
Partisan Strength	0.569*** (0.115)		
Performance × Position	0.132 (0.139)		
Female		−0.568 (0.531)	−0.202 (0.400)
Age 30–39		−0.394 (1.540)	−0.743 (0.761)
Age 40–49		0.579 (1.465)	−1.655* (0.739)
Age 50–59		0.826 (1.532)	−1.883* (0.956)
Age 60+		0.760 (1.582)	−1.198 (0.941)

(Continued)

Table D3. Continued.

Variable	Choice-specific	KMT vs DPP	TPP vs DPP
High School		−0.697 (1.074)	0.092 (1.165)
University		−0.531 (1.159)	0.128 (1.214)
Prior Voting for DPP		−1.554 (1.381)	−2.339* (1.091)
Prior Voting for KMT		0.248 (1.428)	−1.991 (1.219)
Taiwanese Identity		−0.553 (0.541)	−0.063 (0.462)
Tsai's Approval		−1.026* (0.460)	−0.266 (0.398)
Log-Likelihood	−154.65		
McFadden R ²	0.807		
Likelihood ratio test	1297***		

Note: Standard errors are in parentheses. *** $p \leq .001$; ** $p \leq .01$; * $p \leq .05$.